Watercolor Perspective Painting

A step-by-step guide for beginners: a tree-lined road with autumn flower beds



34 steps from first pencil line to finished painting

Built from screenshots of a Facebook reel by themohiart. Colors are kept as they appear in the reel.

What you will paint



1

One-point perspective

Every line of the road, flower beds and treeline runs to a single vanishing point on the horizon. That one idea creates the sense of depth.

2

Light to dark, far to near

The sky and distant trees go in first, then the meadow, flower beds, trunks, road and finally the bright autumn leaves.

3

Loose, layered brushwork

Flowers, foliage and clouds are dabs and overlaps, not careful outlines. Expect imperfect edges and let them stay.

The reel opens with this small reference photo in the corner:



The painting in nine stages



1. Pencil drawing

Steps 1–3

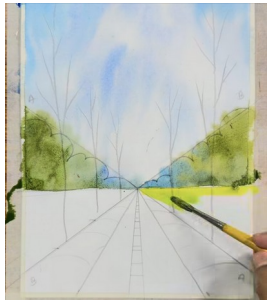
Build the one-point perspective frame, treeline and trunks in light pencil.



2. Sky

Steps 4–7

Loose blue washes and dabbed clouds, with white paper left between.



3. Distant trees

Steps 8–12

Olive-green masses on both sides, with a blue-green haze at the base.



4. Meadow

Steps 13–14

Yellow-green fields that darken toward the foreground.



5. Flower beds

Steps 15–21

Loose dabs of red, orange and yellow, then dark green leaves.



6. Tree trunks

Steps 22–25

Thin brown trunks and forked twigs, small and fine near the horizon.



7. Road

Steps 26–27

Gray road from the vanishing point down, white dashes left bare.



8. Autumn leaves

Steps 28–32

Yellow, orange and maroon clusters on the right; gray-green on the left.



9. Finished painting

Steps 33–34

Step back, compare and study the details.

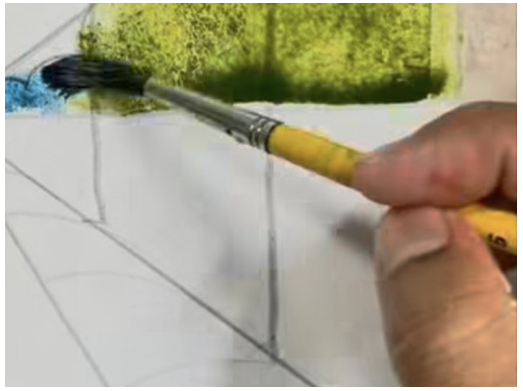
Tools seen in the reel



Graphite pencil

Steps 1–4

Light drawing of the perspective lines, treeline and trunks.



Round brush, yellow handle

Most paint steps

The main brush for the trees, meadow, flowers, road and leaves.



Soft brush for dabbing

Steps 6–7

A fluffy, dark-bristled tip dabbed on the sky to make soft cloud edges.



Fine liner brush

Step 25

A thin, long-bristled brush for trunks and twigs.

Also visible: watercolor paper held flat with its edges taped down (a clean white border shows at the end), a jar of water for rinsing, and a wooden table. Brush sizes are not stated, so use what you have: a medium round brush for most steps and a fine liner for the twigs.

Your color palette

Deep sky blue
#4E7EEB · Steps 4–5
Try: Ultramarine or cobalt blue

Soft sky blue
#98B5DD · Steps 5–7
Try: The same blue, thinned with plenty of water

Blue-green haze
#7AA2AF · Steps 9–11
Try: Cerulean or turquoise, plus a little green

Olive green
#79832D · Steps 8–11
Try: Sap green plus a touch of yellow ochre

Muted olive
#848D4B · Step 12
Try: Olive green, thinned

Yellow-green
#C0D246 · Steps 12–14
Try: Lemon yellow plus a touch of green

Grass green
#52832E · Step 14
Try: Sap green plus a little blue

Dark leaf green
#2D4216 · Steps 19–21
Try: Sap green plus a touch of burnt umber

Coral red
#E3665D · Steps 15–18, 21, 32
Try: Scarlet or permanent red

Orange
#E8853E · Steps 18, 20–21, 29–32
Try: Orange or yellow-orange

Golden yellow
#E1AE42 · Steps 18, 28–30
Try: A warm, bright yellow

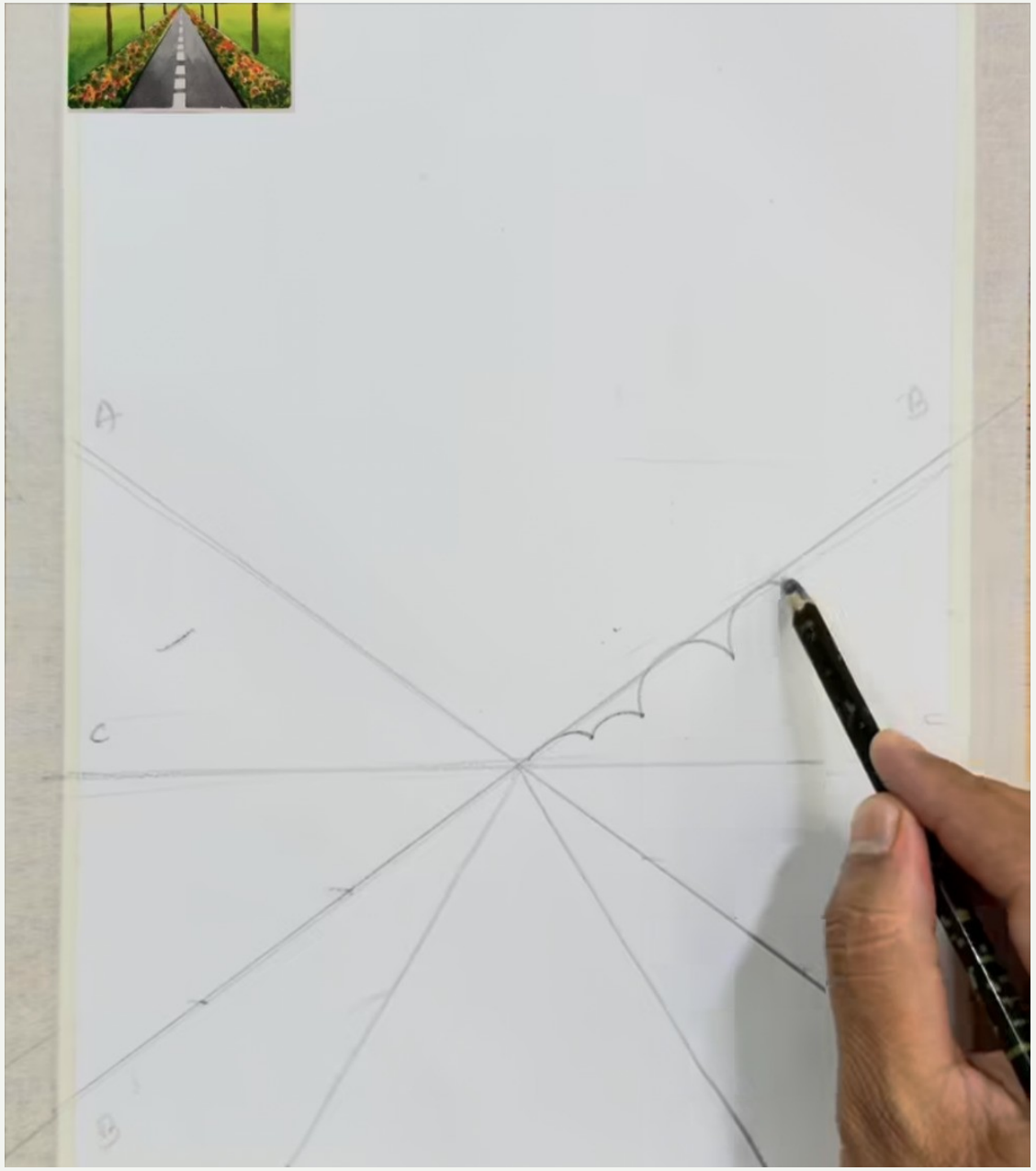
Dark brown
#4B432B · Steps 22–25
Try: Burnt umber or sepia

Road gray
#6D7072 · Steps 26–27
Try: Neutral tint or Payne's gray, thinned

Maroon
#4B3632 · Step 31
Try: Red plus brown, or a dark red-brown

Gray-green
#555E44 · Steps 31–32
Try: Sap green plus a little gray

Hex values were sampled from the screenshots, so they will look a little different on your screen and paper. The reel does not name pigments: the “Try” lines are suggestions only, so match by eye.



STAGE 1 · PENCIL DRAWING

Draw the perspective frame

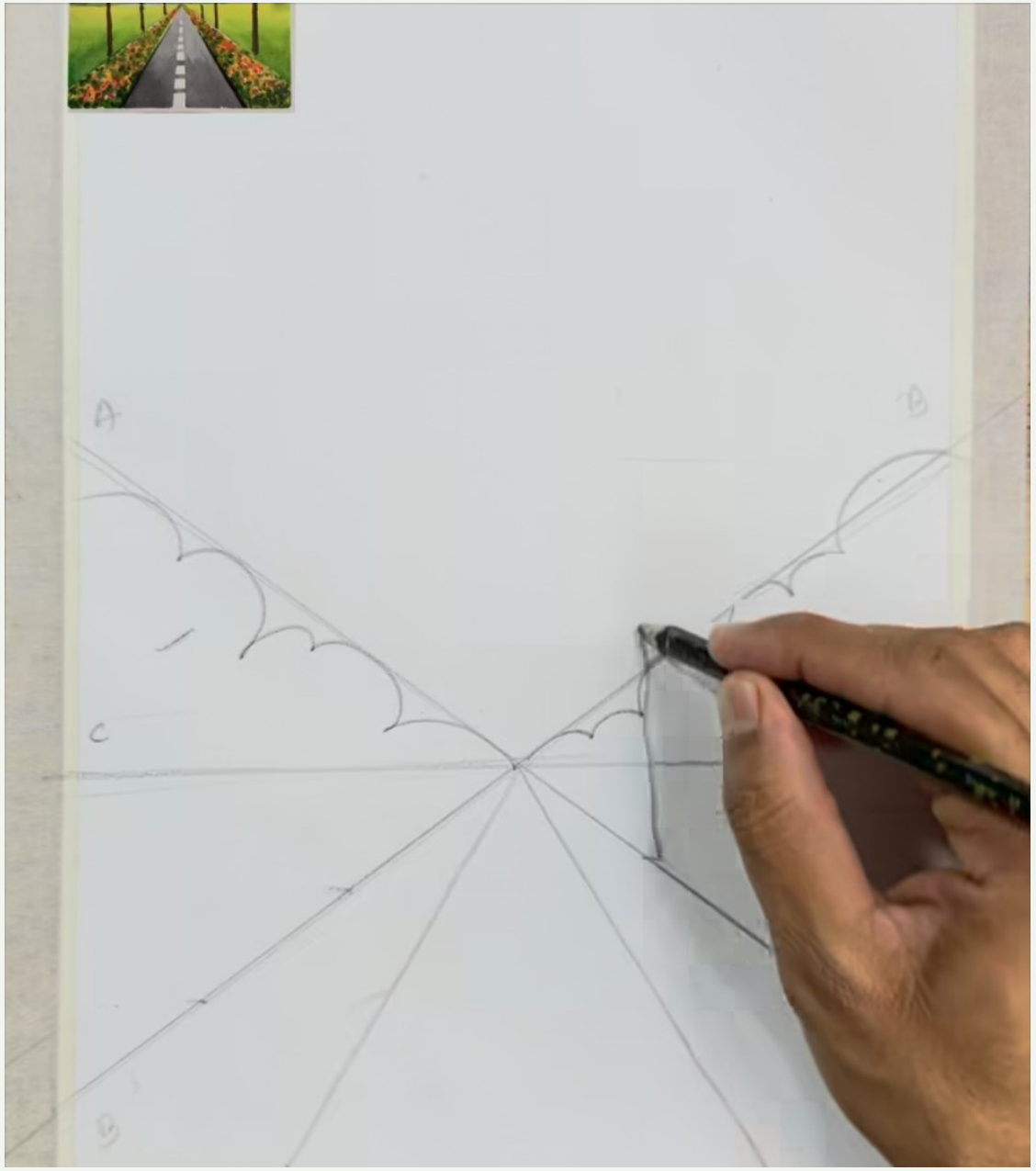
WHAT TO DO

- Lightly draw a horizontal horizon line about 60% of the way down the page.
- Mark one vanishing point on it. Draw two long crossing diagonals through that point, plus a fan of straight lines down to the bottom edge.
- Start the bumpy treeline (small scallops) along the right-hand diagonal.

WATCH FOR

Press very lightly. The small A, B and C letters in the margins are the artist's own guide marks; you don't need to copy them.

NO PAINT YET: PENCIL ONLY



STAGE 1 · PENCIL DRAWING

Mirror the treeline on the left

WHAT TO DO

- Draw the same scalloped treeline along the left diagonal so both sides match.
- Keep the bumps small near the vanishing point and larger toward the edges.
- Extend the right treeline out to the paper's edge and begin the first vertical trunk line.

WATCH FOR

Big shapes in front, small shapes far away: that is what makes the scene look deep.

NO PAINT YET: PENCIL ONLY



STAGE 1 · PENCIL DRAWING

STEP 3 OF 34

Sketch the tree trunks

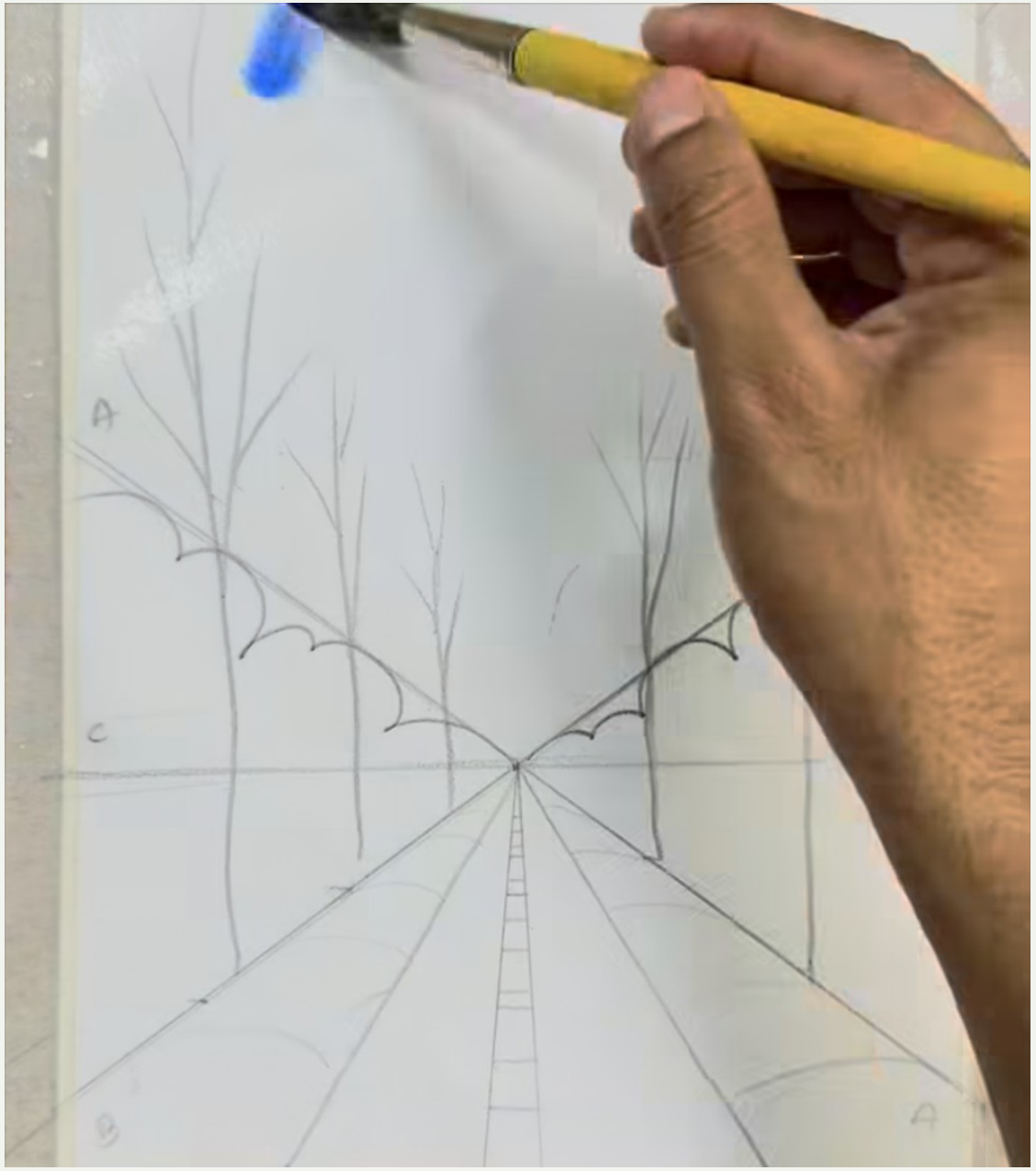
WHAT TO DO

- Draw tall, thin trunks on both sides, each splitting into a few forked twigs near the top.
- Add shorter, thinner trunks in between, standing along the treeline.

WATCH FOR

Trunks shrink toward the vanishing point, so the row of trees seems to recede.

NO PAINT YET: PENCIL ONLY



STAGE 2 · SKY

Pencil done: first blue at the top

WHAT TO DO

- Finish the drawing: the faint ladder-like marks down the middle of the road become the dashed center line.
- Load a round brush with sky blue and touch it to the top edge of the paper.

WATCH FOR

Start high on the page and keep your strokes loose. The sky does not need to be even.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Deep sky blue
#4E7EEB



STAGE 2 · SKY

Spread the blue across the top

WHAT TO DO

- Pull the blue sideways into soft, streaky patches along the top of the sky.
- Leave gaps of bare white paper between the patches.

WATCH FOR

The white gaps become your clouds, so don't fill them in.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Deep sky blue
#4E7EEB

Soft sky blue
#98B5DD



STAGE 2 · SKY

STEP 6 OF 34

Dab cloud patches lower in the sky

WHAT TO DO

- Switch to a soft, dark-bristled brush and dab (don't stroke) a blue patch below the top band.
- Keep the edges uneven and leave white around each patch.

WATCH FOR

Dabbing with the tip leaves a soft, speckled edge that looks like cloud.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Soft sky blue
#98B5DD



STAGE 2 · SKY

Keep dabbing to soften the sky

WHAT TO DO

- Add one or two more dabbed patches and blend their edges into the white.
- Let the blue fade out gradually toward the horizon.

WATCH FOR

Deeper blue at the top, paler near the horizon. Stop before the sky gets busy.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Soft sky blue
#98B5DD



STAGE 3 · DISTANT TREES

Sky done: start the right-hand trees

WHAT TO DO

- Switch to olive green and fill the triangle above the right-hand scalloped line, following its edge.
- Dab so the green looks mottled, not flat.

WATCH FOR

Uneven, speckled paint reads as leaves. Don't smooth it out.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Olive green
#79832D



STAGE 3 · DISTANT TREES

STEP 9 OF 34

Deepen the right trees, add blue at the base

WHAT TO DO

- Build the green up toward the horizon so the mass looks fuller.
- At the base, beside the vanishing point, start a band of blue-green.

WATCH FOR

A cooler, bluer color at the base makes the trees look farther away.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Olive green
#79832D

Blue-green haze
#7AA2AF



STAGE 3 · DISTANT TREES

Run the blue-green haze along the horizon

WHAT TO DO

- Continue the blue-green band along the base of the right treeline, all the way to the vanishing point.
- Let it blend slightly into the green above.

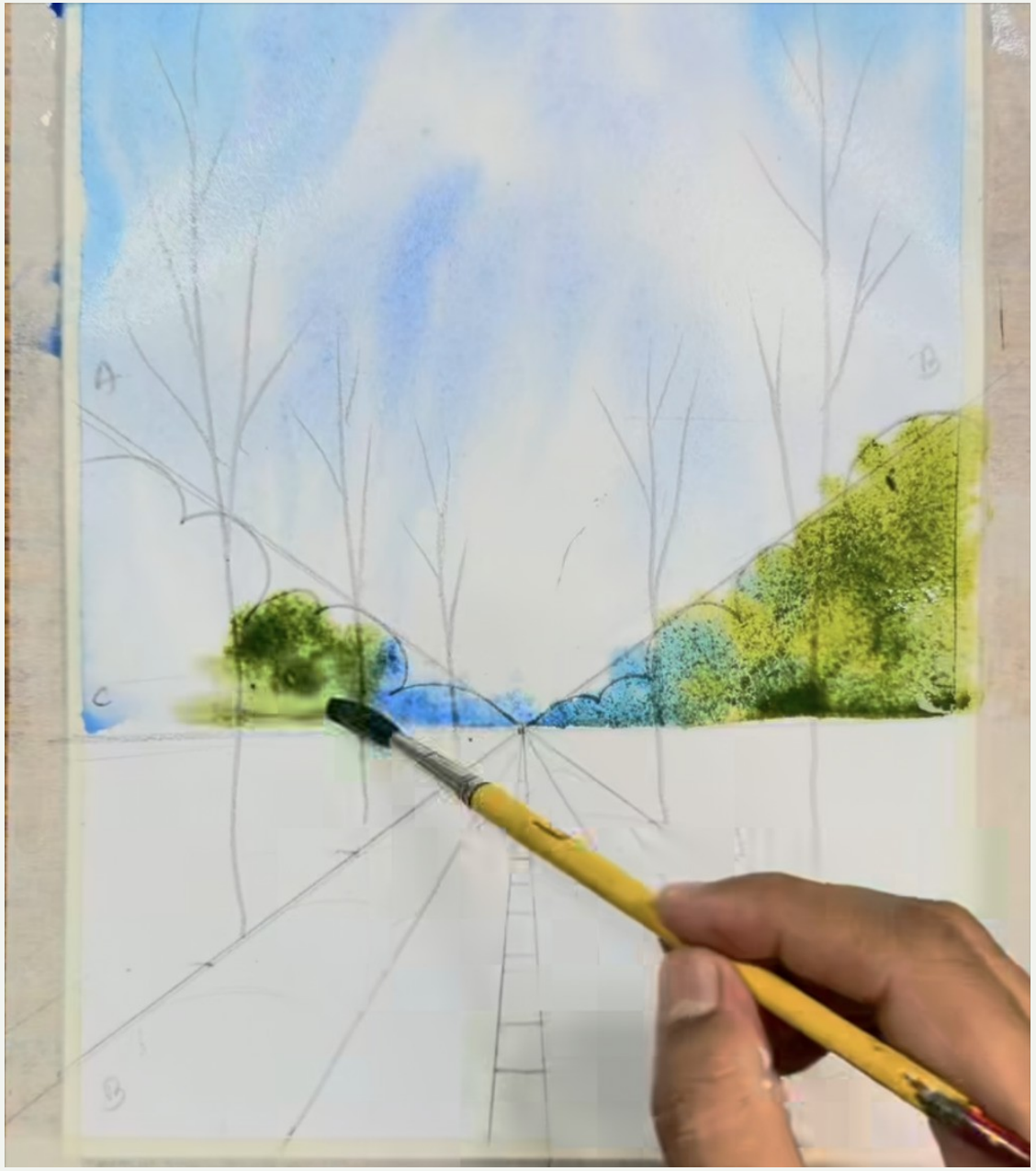
WATCH FOR

Follow the scalloped pencil line so the haze keeps its bumpy edge.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Blue-green haze
#7AA2AF

Olive green
#79832D



STAGE 3 · DISTANT TREES

Begin the left-hand trees

WHAT TO DO

- Dab dark green clumps on the left, mirroring the right-hand trees.
- Add the blue-green strip at the base, running from the vanishing point toward the left.

WATCH FOR

Work in small clumps and leave the bumpy outline visible.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Olive green
#79832D

Blue-green haze
#7AA2AF



STAGE 3 · DISTANT TREES

Fill the left trees, first meadow stripe

WHAT TO DO

- Fill the left treeline so it balances the right one, using some darker and some lighter patches.
- Switch to bright yellow-green and paint a strip just under the horizon on the right.

WATCH FOR

Varied tones keep the trees from looking flat.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Muted olive
#848D4B

Yellow-green
#C0D246



STAGE 4 · MEADOW

Fill the right meadow

WHAT TO DO

- Paint the wedge between the horizon and the outer pencil line on the right in yellow-green.
- Leave the narrow strip next to the road and the road itself unpainted.

WATCH FOR

The narrow strips beside the road stay white for now: they are for the flowers.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Yellow-green
#C0D246



STAGE 4 · MEADOW

Left meadow, then darken the foreground

WHAT TO DO

- Paint the left meadow wedge in yellow-green, matching the right.
- Add darker green along the bottom and outer edge of both meadows and blend it upward into the lighter green.

WATCH FOR

Light in the distance, dark up close: this deepens the sense of space.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Yellow-green
#C0D246

Grass green
#52832E



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

STEP 15 OF 34

First red dabs for the flower beds

WHAT TO DO

- Load a small round brush with red and dab spots along the right flower-bed strip.
- Keep the dabs random and uneven in size.

WATCH FOR

Don't paint individual flowers. Loose dabs read as a bed of blooms.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Coral red
#E3665D



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

Spread the red along both beds

WHAT TO DO

- Continue the red dabs up the right strip toward the vanishing point, smaller and paler as you go.
- Start dabbing red on the left strip, near the bottom.

WATCH FOR

Larger, stronger dabs near the bottom edge (close); small, pale dabs far away.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Coral red
#E3665D



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

STEP 17 OF 34

Finish the red on the left bed

WHAT TO DO

- Work up the left strip with the same loose dabs.
- Match the size and spacing to the right bed so both sides feel balanced.

WATCH FOR

Leave gaps between the dabs. Orange and yellow fill them next.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Coral red
#E3665D



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

STEP 18 OF 34

Fill the gaps with orange and yellow

WHAT TO DO

- Switch to orange, then yellow-orange, and dab between and over the red spots.
- Let the colors overlap so they mix on the paper.

WATCH FOR

Overlapping, see-through dabs create a warm, glowing mass of flowers.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

- **Orange** #E8853E
- **Golden yellow** #E1AE42
- **Coral red** #E3665D



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

STEP 19 OF 34

Add leaf-green touches to the beds

WHAT TO DO

- Pick up dark green and dab small leaf shapes among the flowers, starting at the bottom of the right bed.
- Keep plenty of orange showing.

WATCH FOR

Go easy with the dark green at first. It is easy to add more and hard to take away.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Dark leaf green
#2D4216



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

STEP 20 OF 34

Keep adding green along the beds

WHAT TO DO

- Continue the green dabs up the right bed.
- Move to the left bed and repeat, keeping the pattern random.

WATCH FOR

Vary the size of the dabs. Even spacing looks mechanical.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Dark leaf green
#2D4216

Orange
#E8853E



STAGE 5 · FLOWER BEDS

Finish the beds and define their edges

WHAT TO DO

- Add dark green along the outer and bottom edges of each bed to define its shape.
- Check that both beds look balanced: flowers in the middle, leaf-green around them.

WATCH FOR

A short brown stroke for the first tree trunk appears at the right here. That is the next step.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

- **Dark leaf green** #2D4216
- **Orange** #E8853E
- **Coral red** #E3665D



STAGE 6 · TREE TRUNKS

Paint the first tree trunk

WHAT TO DO

- With brown on a thin round brush, pull a line up from the meadow edge on the right.
- Trace the pencil trunk and let the line thin out as you go up.

WATCH FOR

Real trunks are not ruler-straight. A slightly wavy line looks natural.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Dark brown
#4B432B



STAGE 6 · TREE TRUNKS

Take the trunk to the top, start the twigs

WHAT TO DO

- Carry the trunk up to the top edge of the paper.
- Near the top, start thin, forking twigs using just the tip of the brush.

WATCH FOR

Branches split into smaller and smaller twigs. A lighter touch makes a thinner line.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Dark brown
#4B432B



STAGE 6 · TREE TRUNKS

Add branches and a second trunk

WHAT TO DO

- Add forked side branches along the main trunk.
- Paint a shorter second trunk to its left, with its own thin twigs.

WATCH FOR

The shorter trunk stands farther back, so keep it thinner.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Dark brown
#4B432B



STAGE 6 · TREE TRUNKS

STEP 25 OF 34

Paint the remaining trunks with a fine brush

WHAT TO DO

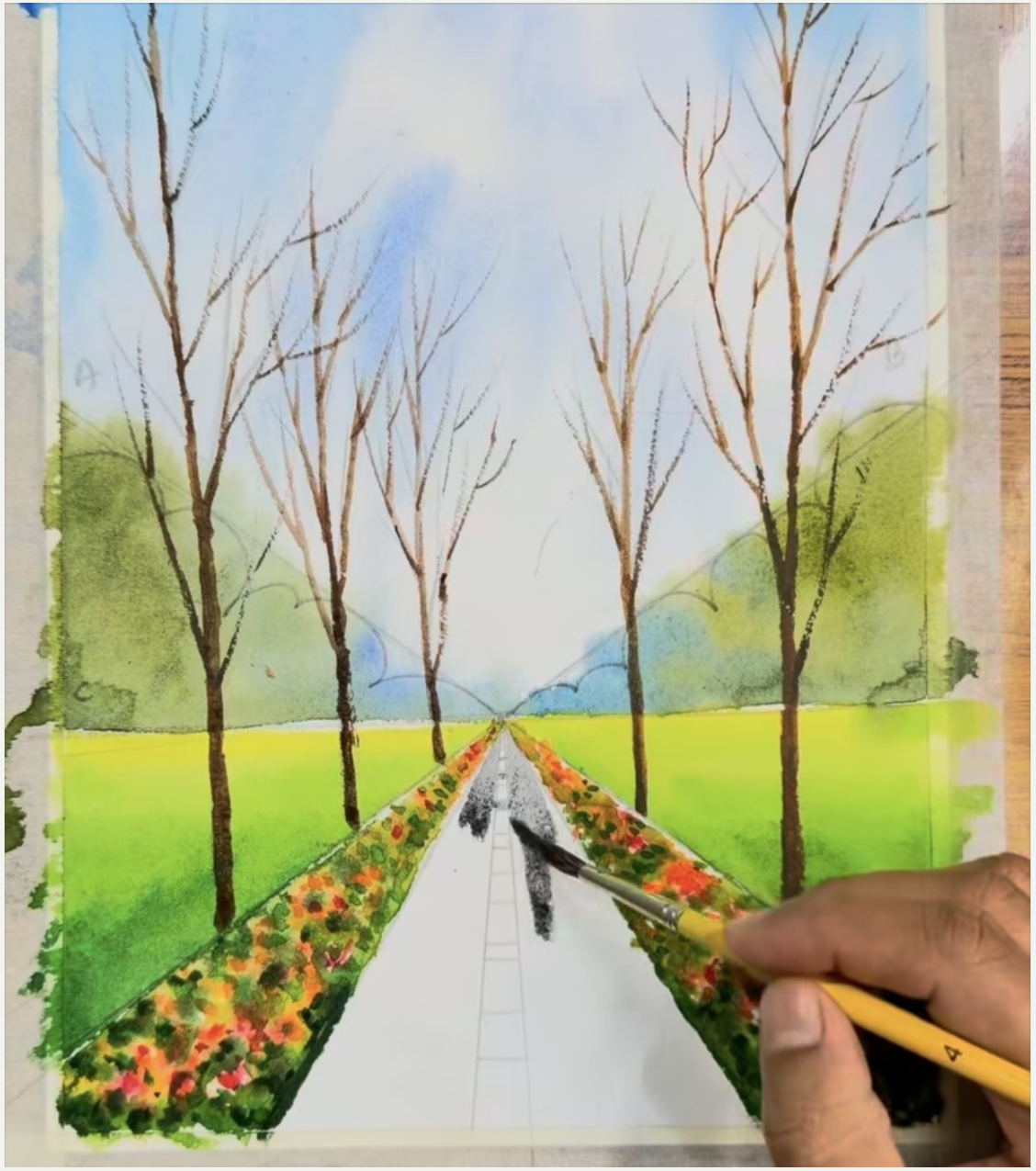
- Switch to a thin, long-bristled liner brush for the rest of the trunks and twigs.
- Work across the left side and the middle, tracing your pencil trunks.

WATCH FOR

Trees near the vanishing point are small and thin. Keep the brush light.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Dark brown
#4B432B



STAGE 7 · ROAD

Start the road at the vanishing point

WHAT TO DO

- Load a brush with dark gray and begin the road at the vanishing point.
- Paint around the pencil center-line marks so they stay white.

WATCH FOR

Those unpainted rungs become the white dashed line, so avoid covering them.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Road gray
#6D7072



STAGE 7 · ROAD

Fill in the road

WHAT TO DO

- Work down toward the bottom edge, filling both sides of the center line.
- Keep the road a little lighter in the distance and slightly darker at the bottom.
- Let the bottom edge go a bit ragged, as it does in the reel.

WATCH FOR

Leave the white dashes untouched. They shrink toward the vanishing point.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Road gray
#6D7072



STAGE 8 · AUTUMN LEAVES

Autumn leaves: start with yellow

WHAT TO DO

- Pick up bright yellow and dab leaf clusters at the tips of the tall right-hand tree's branches.
- Use small, irregular shapes, not perfect leaves.

WATCH FOR

Start with the lightest color. Orange and dark tones go on top.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Golden yellow
#E1AE42



STAGE 8 · AUTUMN LEAVES

STEP 29 OF 34

Layer orange over the yellow

WHAT TO DO

- Dab orange onto the clusters, partly overlapping the yellow.
- Leave some of the yellow showing.

WATCH FOR

Overlaps give the foliage a glowing, layered look.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Orange
#E8853E

Golden yellow
#E1AE42



STAGE 8 · AUTUMN LEAVES

STEP 30 OF 34

Build up the leaf clusters

WHAT TO DO

- Keep adding orange and yellow clusters along the upper branches.
- Vary the size of the clusters.

WATCH FOR

Leave some sky showing between clusters so the tree stays airy.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

Orange
#E8853E

Golden yellow
#E1AE42



STAGE 8 · AUTUMN LEAVES

Add dark leaves, then green on the left

WHAT TO DO

- Dab a few maroon (dark red-brown) clusters among the orange on the right tree for contrast.
- Switch to gray-green and start leaf clusters on the left-hand trees.

WATCH FOR

A few dark clusters make the bright oranges pop.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

- **Maroon** #4B3632
- **Gray-green** #555E44
- **Orange** #E8853E



STAGE 8 · AUTUMN LEAVES

Finishing touches

WHAT TO DO

- Add gray-green and orange-red leaf clusters across the left and middle trees.
- Add a thin dark line where the road meets the flower beds.
- Once everything is dry, peel off any tape to reveal a clean white border (general tip).

WATCH FOR

The painting is now complete. The reel pulls back to show the whole sheet on the table.

COLORS IN THIS STEP

- **Gray-green** #555E44
- **Orange** #E8853E
- **Coral red** #E3665D



STAGE 9 · FINISHED PAINTING

The finished painting

WHAT TO DO

- Do all the lines meet at one vanishing point?
- Is it pale in the sky and distance, and deep in color up front?
- Do the left and right sides echo each other without matching exactly?

WATCH FOR

Use this view as your reference when you check your own painting.

FULL PALETTE ON SLIDE 5



STAGE 9 · FINISHED PAINTING

STEP 34 OF 34

Close-up details to study

WHAT TO DO

- Flower beds: loose dabs of red, orange and yellow with dark green between them.
- Road: even gray, with white dashes shrinking toward the vanishing point.
- Trees: thin branches against the sky, with bright leaf clusters only at the tips.

WATCH FOR

Run your eye along the road edges. Every line aims at the same point.

FULL PALETTE ON SLIDE 5

Tips for your first attempt

1 Practice the dabs first

Try the cloud dabs, flower dabs and leaf clusters on a scrap of paper before you commit to the painting.

2 Test every color on scrap paper

Watercolor dries lighter than it looks wet. A quick swatch saves a lot of guessing.

3 Keep the pencil light

Graphite shows through pale washes, and heavy lines are hard to erase once painted over.

4 Pause and let layers dry

Wet-on-wet blends softly. Painting beside a wet area can blur edges you wanted crisp. Wait when in doubt.

5 Photograph each stage

Compare your photos with the step slides to catch problems early, like a vanishing point that has drifted.

6 Aim for the feel, not a copy

Your dabs, clouds and leaves will not match the reel exactly, and they don't need to.

These are general watercolor tips, not statements from the reel.